



FIGURE SKATING'S PAST, PRESENT & FUTURE

THE MANY ERAS OF NATHAN LAPALMA

Nathan LaPalma was the skater the world wanted and is now the coach the American Skating Association needs. He's famously friendly and approachable despite his long-standing fame, and he always keeps a keen focus on his students' success. An ice skating expert whose passion for the craft suffuses his work, LaPalma is now ready to introduce the world to the next generation of skating celebrities.

Nathan LaPalma, photographed by Eliza Martin

BEGINNINGS

The son of a hockey coach and an ice skating professional, LaPalma was practically born on the ice, having spent most of his childhood gliding down the glacial gloss of Calgary, Alberta, Canada. In multiple interviews, he's stated that he learned the importance of hard work and perseverance early by watching the way his parents committed to their family and professions.

LaPalma began his skating career at the age of 4, practicing alongside his mother for hours before school, and continued the craft until he won his very first prize at age 10. At 14, his immaculate triple-triple combinations earned him his first gold medal as a singles skater.

A PRODIGIOUS PARTNERSHIP

When he was 17, LaPalma's family moved to Three Pines, Colo., where his mother had received an offer to coach ice skating at the Three Pines Ice Rink. Soon after the

move, LaPalma found a skating partner in Carol Donnelly, a skater with undeniable raw talent but a lack of polish that held her back throughout her junior career. As partners, LaPalma and Donnelly's fame and success skyrocketed, and the two went on to receive dozens of medals at national and international competitions alongside the admiration of audiences worldwide.

However, the pair's prime wasn't without controversy; LaPalma became notorious for leaving a long string of jilted lovers across the planet, and Donnelly was known to lash out at judges whose criticisms of her appearance and lack of classic gracefulness she felt to be unfair.

HIS TENURE AS A TEACHER

After making the controversial choice to separate from Donnelly to retire his skates at the apex of his career, LaPalma chose to follow in his mother's footsteps and become a figure skating coach at the very same rink where she once worked.

When questioned about his decision, LaPalma simply said, "I've accomplished all I need to as a competitor, but skating's in my blood, and I know I'm not alone in that. I'd like to help shape the future of the sport. As much as I've loved working with

Carol, it's time for a change. Plus, it's close to family. My parents won't be around forever."

However, the dynamic duo of LaPalma and Donnelly were not to be separated for long; Donnelly herself would soon join the staff of the rink as an administrator, judge and American Skating Association representative. Donnelly currently reigns supreme as the type of tough-but-fair judge she once butted heads with. In a move to put Three Pines even more squarely on the map, the two recruited the recently retired skating socialite Marcus Lourdes, a choice that has indeed in the years since solidified Three Pines as the go-to proving ground for young, American skating talent.

FORGING THE FUTURE OF FIGURE SKATING

Currently, LaPalma is focusing his attention on only three students, all of whom are esteemed, up-and-coming figure skaters in their own rights: Harrison Campbell, Sofia de la Torre and, most recently, Lillian Varma.

The utterly captivating Campbell has collected considerable commendations for his capability and control on the ice. He's

been skating for almost as long as he's been walking and wiping the floor with his competition for just about that time as well. Beyond his athletic accolades, Campbell has seen a meteoric rise in popularity over the past three years. This upward trend began when the then-16-year-old gave a tear-jerking interview to skating news blog The Lee Report about his abandonment by his father as a boy. However, the sustained upward momentum of Campbell's online profile can't be attributed to him alone; his manager and mother Anne Campbell, an ever-present mentor figure at Campbell's side, has been instrumental in cultivating his popularity.

Though LaPalma's training with Varma only began a little over a month ago, she's coming into his tutelage hot off the heels of a decade-long career working with Marcus Lourdes, with whom her relationship recently ended for unknown reasons. Having started ice skating to help treat the stiffness and swelling in her joints caused by lupus, Varma has always been

interested in eclipsing the expectations that others have foisted onto her and is regarded as somewhat of a prodigy by those in the know. She's certainly one to watch, especially now that she's paired with the skating powerhouse and social media darling, Harrison Campbell.

While de la Torre has fewer medals or accolades to her name than her fellow LaPalma teammates, she carries a solid record of silver- and bronze-level achievements and an incredible athletic stamina that allows her to pack her programs with occasionally overzealous tricks. While de la Torre has not received an invitation to the ASA's prestigious National Tournament this year, she remains determined to make the most of the rest of her prime years as a skater.

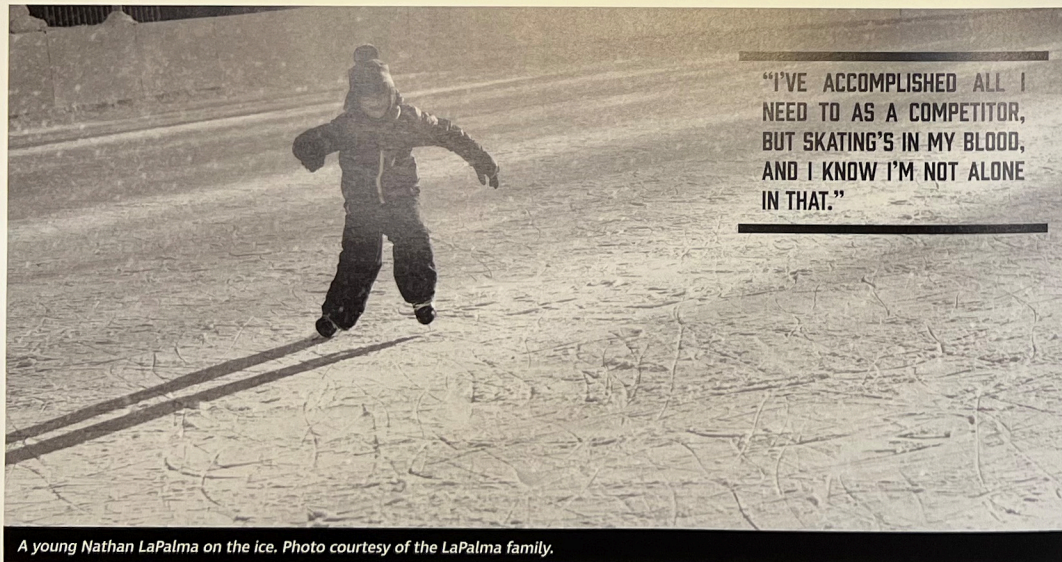
However, popularity would mean nothing if it wasn't backed by talent, and talent would be wasted if it wasn't cultivated by a worthy coach. With Campbell and Varma currently preparing for the ASA's National

Tournament in a few short months, it seems as though LaPalma is providing the mentorship the two need as they are poised to recreate the iconic success of his and Donnelly's so many years ago, carrying a proud skating tradition into a fresh, exciting future.

Written by Kingston Lee

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is the sole author and founder of the brilliant blog The Lee Report and he is a leading journalist in the world of figure skating. When he is not writing rinkside, Kingston spends most of his time with his cats, Genevieve and Pam.



A young Nathan LaPalma on the ice. Photo courtesy of the LaPalma family.



A roaring crowd cheers on Nathan LaPalma's student, Harrison Campbell, at last year's ASA National Tournament. Photographed by Eliza Martin.



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